continued with some officers from Punjab and Haryana [a state that came into being on 1 November 1966] and some from the Delhi Administration managing its affairs. In my tenure itself I have seen about 18 IGPs and an equal number of superintendents. That gives an average of not more than nine months per head. The right attitude towards the job at hand was lacking because these people came here on a one-step promotion; they merely marked time here.

The then-DIG at Tihar headquarters, Jaydev Sarangi, from the Delhi and Andaman Civil Services (non-police) was the superintendent of Jail 1 from 1987 to 1990. He threw light on the situation as it then existed:

The working of each jail was the total responsibility of the superintendent then. The IG and DIG never interacted with the jail as far as its administration was concerned. They never made visits to the prison to see what was going on. Yet, they had the budgetary strings in their hands. The rations for 8000 prisoners were all controlled by them. But what the prisoners were actually getting, its quality, its quantity, was never looked into.

Opportunities for corruption for the jail staff were in plenty. For instance, we are required by the jail manual to provide each prisoner with three blankets … But on payment of gratification money the tougher and richer prisoners could easily get more blankets. But since the issue to each jail was fixed, it was the weaker and poorer sections who would suffer, with, at times, some of them having to do with no blankets at all. For greater amounts of gratification one could get quilts from outside. These quilts could prove a big security problem as they could be used to store anything from drugs to weapons with none being any the wiser. I had all quilts seized and removed. As for the blankets they were all collected, counted and distributed back to the prisoners with each getting his quota of three. Periodical checks would then be made and the offenders punished.

At that time there was no complaint or suggestion system in the jail. One was started, though unlike today, it was ‘fixed’. The complainant was interviewed. Lots of the complaints pertained to extortion and corruption by the junior jail staff. Again, through gratification, a prisoner could get himself transferred to any prison of his choice. And he would have so many reasons for it. A suggestion was made to the superintendents of the other jails also that the distribution of prisoners in each jail should be according to the alphabetical order of the prisoner’s name. This was agreed upon and incorporated.

These were some of the ways in which the lower staff had indulged in corruption. They did not want the system to be changed and so were obviously bitter. One of the deputy superintendents planned out his revenge. He was making a large number of prisoners sign a complaint against me, supposedly written by one of the prisoners himself. Getting wind of the plan we were alerted and managed to recover bits of paper, which, when joined together, revealed that it was a draft, in the deputy’s handwriting, of the letter supposed to have been written by a prisoner.

I sent a photocopy of the torn and reassembled letter to the Lt. Governor’s office for his information.

Apparently, there have been people coming as officers to Tihar who have stood by their conscience and tried to do their job properly. But due to an earlier uninspiring, unambitious and lacklustre leadership, the system had proved itself to be stronger.